TERAI-DUAR SAVANNAS

Home to the world's tallest grasslands

This narrow region at the base of the Himalayas comprises a mosaic of river grassland, savannas, and forests. Much of the grassland is unusually high, which provides excellent cover for both predators and their prey. The Terai-Duar is home to numerous species of hooved mammals, including at least five different deer species, the endangered Asiatic wild buffalo, and the Indian rhinoceros. At the top of the Terai food chain is the tiger, populations of which are increasing here, especially in established national parks such as Chitwan and Bardia in Nepal. Leopards and the rare clouded leopard are also resident. Three bird species—the spiny babbler, the gray-crowned prinia, and the Manipur bush-quail—have ranges that are restricted to the Terai-Duar and neighboring regions.

Fertile floodplain

Alluvial or floodplain grasslands are submerged during monsoon rains and replenished with fertile silt, prompting rapid grass growth once the waters retreat. However, the moist, nutrient-rich soil is ideal for cultivation, and much of the land has been converted to agriculture. The survival of the Terai-Duar's wildlife depends on an extensive network of protected areas connected by wildlife corridors so that species such as tigers, elephants, and rhinoceros can move freely between reserves, with as little interaction with humans as possible.



EGYPTIAN VULTURE

PLIGHT OF THE VULTURES
India's vulture populations crashed spectacularly in the 1990s after veterinary drugs used to treat cattle were ingested by birds that fed on livestock carcasses. Although one drug has since been banned, it will take time for the slow-breeding species to recover.

Has Asia's highest populations of tigers and rhinos



SWAMP DEER

Manipur bush-quail was thought extinct until found here in 2006

ENDANGERED DEER
Terai grasslands are home to the barasingha, or swamp deer, which has large, splayed hooves that can cope with its swampy habitat. A vital prey species for tigers and leopards, barasingha numbers are threatened by habitat loss and hunting.



MUGGER CROCODILE

ENDANGERED REPTILE
Mugger crocodile populations declined in the 1950s and 60s mainly due to hunting for their skin. Despite improved protection and captive breeding programs, the mugger still suffers because of habitat loss.

The Terai-Duar is one of Earth's most **biologically outstanding habitats**